TOWARDS TEMPORARY THAW—DÉTENTE

Détente—Meaning

The Cuban Missile Crisis was an eye-opener for both the superpowers and also a *catalytic* learning experience for them. This experience made them aware of the impending threat of mutual destruction with the growing parity of American and Soviet military capabilities that made co-existence or non-existence appear to be the only alternative. Therefore, easing of tensions between the two superpowers became necessary. At the American University, in 1963, President John F. Kennedy explained the necessity of reduction of tensions and lessening the risk of war.

"Today, should total war ever break out again—no matter how—our two countries would become the primary targets. It is an ironical but accurate fact that the two strongest powers are the two in the most danger of devastation. We are both caught up in a vicious and dangerous cycle in which suspicion on one side breeds suspicion on the other and new weapons beget counter weapons.

In short, both the United States and its allies, and the Soviet Union and its allies, have a mutually deep interest in a just and genuine peace and in halting the arms race….

So let us not be blind to our differences, but let us also direct attention to our common interests and to the means by which those differences can be resolved. And if we cannot end now our differences, at least we can help make the world safe for diversity". [11]

Though Kennedy's exposition signalled a shift in the American policy towards Soviet Union, but the chief architect of détente was Richard Nixon and his National Security Adviser, Henry Kissinger. In the words of Kissinger, détente sought to create "a vested interest in cooperation and restraint", "an environment in which competitors can regulate and restrain their differences and ultimately move from competition to cooperation".

Later, President Jimmy Carter defined détente as the easing of tension between two nations and the evolution of new means by which the two nations could live together in peace. The Soviets